

While selling second-hand electronics might seem an easy way to make money, it has its own share of challenges. Jayant Jha, Co-founder and CEO of Yaantra, a recommerce platform shares his learnings, “The major barrier that we face in selling a refurbished smartphone is that consumers still have apprehensions while buying a refurbished product. In India, there are very few trusted platforms that provide certified phones, rigorous quality checks and warranty assurance.



Refurbished products are often perceived to be of low quality. People, in general, have a misconception that all refurbished products are used or secondhand. Refurbished doesn't necessarily mean a used product, but they could be the products kept on display or used in demos and hence the package-box is opened. Once package is opened, it cannot be counted as brand new and hence has to be labelled as refurbished. Few people perceive refurbished goods as faulty products hastily pushed on to the next consumer.

Yaantra has been working persistently to address the quality-related barriers with assured warranty. Door-step service is another facility provided to customers to address trust-related issues which customers may have and provides them convenience besides removing the affordability barrier.”

Recommerce is a massive market, especially in India which has seen an 8.8% growth year-on-year as per the latest Counterpoint report on the state of the global refurbished smartphone market. Considering the fact that 82% of the smartphones sold in India don't even enter the refurbished domain, that's a huge market opportunity up for grabs. This doesn't mean that the 82% constitutes of working phones that are lying about. No, a lot of these smartphones are also non-functional which then requires a little bit of

investment before it can enter the refurbished market. It's either that or recycling. That's how recommerce players differentiate themselves from the likes of Quickr or OLX. There are even services with physical stores such as CEX which accepts working devices and resells them after grading the overall quality of the gadget.

RECYCLING

India generates about 2 million metric tonnes of e-waste annually and only 0.036 metric tonne of that e-waste was treated in the country in 2016-2017. Of this miniscule amount, 95% was handled by the informal sector. This is set to change thanks to a few amendments that were made to the E-waste Management Rules in 2016 and 2018. Only authorised e-waste handlers can take up the job of recycling e-waste. This will help release the stranglehold that the informal sector has on this market.

Moreover, with the introduction of the Producer Responsibility Organisation, manufacturers have been tasked

into the Indian ICT ecosystem, they've even taken up the mantle of educating their partners about responsible e-waste management. “As a leading technology distribution Company in India, it is our mandate to stop the degradation of the environment due to e-waste. The aim of starting these collection points in each of the RP tech India branch is to ensure that we are accessible to end-users. We will leverage the Partner Connect platform in collaboration with our vendor partners to reach out to a maximum number of partners across India and spread awareness,” said Rajesh Goenka, Director, Sales and Marketing, RP tech India.

There's also a lot of money to be made in recycling. A UN report presented earlier this year cited an example of a Chinese e-waste recycler which had been producing more cobalt than what the whole of China mines in one year. There's a lot of processes involved in extracting resources from the earth but obtaining the same from e-waste is a much simpler process. This should



to meet certain e-waste management targets and they're mandated to keep increasing these targets by 10 per cent on an annual basis. As of now, there are about 178 such government-accredited e-waste processing entities in the country. Rashi Peripherals, a national distributor for a lot of the PC components and peripheral brands detailed their initiatives around e-waste management. Over the last year, they've opened up four e-waste collection centres and 50 smaller collection points where consumers can get rid of their old electronic hardware in a responsible manner. Since they're entrenched

certainly spark more interest from companies and thus, reduce our carbon footprint along the way.

A LONG WAY AHEAD

It goes without saying that we're in the early stages of setting up a proper framework towards ensuring an efficient mechanism for e-waste management. As of now, the informal sector in India accepts a lot of e-waste from other countries and recycles them in a manner that causes harm to the environment. This can easily change for the better with some legislation and some push from the corporates. 